



Home Is Where The Money Is

Telecommuting is not just a trend that will fade away... It is fast becoming a way of life more and more professionals are choosing

Meera Vankipuram

"Earn Rs 4,000-10,000 every month by online surfing. Full/Part-Time from Home/Cyber café. Franchisees required all over India. Contact: ..."
"Work 1-2 hours per day on home/office Internet. Earn extra income without leaving your present occupation. Training provided. Contact: ..."

Looks familiar? It's splashed all over the classifieds in newspapers, in notices stuck on local trains and buses and in dozens of handouts distributed at busy street corners. While the reliability of a significant portion of these notices is suspect, working from home is an option being explored not just by homemakers but also by full-fledged professionals tired of the corporate rat race.

The proliferation of the Internet and cell phones has given several users the choice of exploring alternate careers within the

comfort of their homes. And web-based ventures that survived the dot-com crash are providing such opportunities to people in India and abroad.

Programmer For Hire

A 29-year-old programmer with five years of experience in IT is resigning from a top firm to do freelance assignments, working from home. "I have been offered a freelance assignment from a US-based firm to develop Web-based applications using Flash and Flash Communication Server," says Sanjeev Menon. The project, spread over a few months, will earn him as much as \$1,300 (Rs 56,500) per month.

Sites such as www.rentacoder.com help programmers like Sanjeev touch base with companies and individuals seeking freelancers. These sites charge 15 per cent of the programmer's pay for every project sourced through their service. "The clients rate you based on your performance, which is then displayed on the site," says

Sanjeev. With a rating of about 600, out of 93,000 programmers listed on the site, Sanjeev is aiming to head the top of the pile soon. A better ranking obviously means more lucrative offers. Who needs placement services in such a convenient setup?

If you are a programmer, tired of a structured corporate career, head to getafreelancer.com, rentacoder.com, scriptlance.com and elance.com—to code and earn, without leaving home!

The Write Stuff

Freelance journalism has been around for a while but thanks to the Web, sourcing projects has never been easier. As an offshoot of the outsourcing boom, journalists in India can now freelance for foreign publications on a wide variety of subjects.

Chennai-based Power Quill (www.powerquill.com) is one such company that employs a network of freelancers and is the brainchild of former business journalists K Nitya Kalyani and Arun Natarajan.